

Sector Brief

SNAPSHOT

EDUCATION · EDTECH · SKILLING · WORKFORCE

Week of 27 July 2026 | 15 stories | 9 countries

This week in brief. A tumultuous week: India's education minister resigned after weeks of exam-integrity protests, while Vietnam's largest garment maker shrank from 4,000 workers to 27 as manufacturing displacement accelerated across the region. Capital and policy kept racing toward the retraining layer regardless — Singapore launched a five-year youth-skilling plan, KAIST signed a \$300 million AI lab with Nvidia, and Japan opened a new funding channel for vocational schools — even as Hyundai's union struck over robot-driven job security and Indonesia logged its worst manufacturing layoffs of the year.

INDIA

VIETNAM

PHILIPPINES

THAILAND

SINGAPORE

INDONESIA

SOUTH KOREA

JAPAN

USA

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INDIA

Exam-leak protests force resignation of India's education minister

Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned on 25 July after weeks of youth-led protests over a leaked NEET-UG medical entrance exam that forced a retest for more than 2.27 million students. The fall is only the second ministerial scandal-resignation of the Modi era and puts India's exam-security infrastructure under a political spotlight.

Nikkei Asia · 2026-07-25

India's manufacturing incentives created 1.45 million jobs

India's Production Linked Incentive schemes drew ₹2.4 trillion in investment and generated 1.45 million jobs across 14 sectors by March 2026, government data tabled in Parliament showed. Labour-intensive sectors like food processing created far more jobs per rupee invested than capital-intensive ones like solar panels, which produced just 14,794 jobs from ₹64,873 crore in investment.

Business Standard · 2026-07-21

VIETNAM

Vietnamese investors link chip-talent pipelines to venture dealflow

As Vietnam races to train 50,000 semiconductor professionals by 2030, education experts argue that curriculum reform alone will not close the gap — universities must teach adaptability, not fixed knowledge. GenAI Fund managing director Laura Nguyen put it plainly: a strong talent pipeline is also a strong dealflow pipeline.

Vietnam News (VNS) · 2026-07-20

Vietnam's shrunken garment giant now runs on pickleball courts

Garmex Saigon, once a five-factory manufacturer employing roughly 4,000 workers, has shrunk to just 27 employees after losing every garment order since 2023, posting a VND 26.4 billion loss in the first half of 2026. More than half its revenue now comes from leasing factory land for pickleball courts rather than making clothes.

ZNews (via Vietnam.vn) · 2026-07-24

PHILIPPINES

Philippine export-zone investment jumps 67% on manufacturing boom

PEZA approved 174 new and expansion projects worth P151.9 billion between January and July 2026, up 67% year-on-year, projected to generate \$5.9 billion in exports and 26,047 direct jobs. Manufacturing — led by electronics and semiconductors — remained the biggest driver of approvals.

Context.ph · 2026-07-24

A reborn Manila hotel lures Filipino hospitality talent home

Ahead of its December reopening, Mandarin Oriental Manila is filling 390 positions, drawing hospitality-school graduates and Filipino workers based in Bangkok, Hong Kong and the Middle East back home. General manager Franck Droin says the hotel is prioritising service aptitude over pure credentials as it rebuilds its opening team twelve years after the original property closed.

Orange Magazine PH · 2026-07-24

THAILAND

Thailand launches five-ministry push to retrain an ageing workforce

Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul unveiled 'THAILAND²: Powering Up Thailand, Elevating Human Capital,' uniting five ministries — higher education, social development, education, labour and agriculture — around upskilling and lifelong learning as the country confronts an ageing population and AI-driven disruption. The plan links a credit-bank system to short courses across industry, services and agriculture, though no budget or timetable has been announced yet.

The Nation Thailand · 2026-07-21

SINGAPORE

Singapore commits to 30,000 annual 'job taster' placements by 2030

President Tharman Shanmugaratnam launched the SG Youth Plan on 25 July, a five-year initiative reaching more than 500,000 young people aged 15 to 35 with workplace 'job taster' stints, mentoring, and \$500 'curiosity credits' for disadvantaged youth. Overseas internship placements will double to 3,000 a year, and mentor numbers will grow five-fold to 5,000 by 2030.

The Straits Times · 2026-07-25

Singapore diagnoses a 'capability debt' between new skills and old jobs

A survey of 335 HR professionals across more than 40 sectors found Singapore organisations are building employee skills faster than they are redesigning jobs to use them, a gap researchers labelled 'capability debt.' Singapore Polytechnic responded by launching the Human Capital Collaboratory, a new job-redesign consultancy platform backed by the Singapore Business Federation, Omni HR and Workato. The finding points to a concrete market gap in applied job-redesign services that HR-tech and workforce-consulting investors can target.

TechNode Global · 2026-07-20

INDONESIA

Indonesian manufacturing layoffs hit 32,389 as PMI slumps

Indonesia's Manpower Ministry recorded 32,389 layoffs in the first half of 2026, concentrated in West Java, Banten and East Java, as the S&P Global Manufacturing PMI plunged to 46.9 in June from 50 in May. A presidential labour adviser said actual layoff numbers likely exceed the official count, prompting President Prabowo to stand up a dedicated Layoff Task Force.

Asia News Network (The Jakarta Post) · 2026-07-21

SOUTH KOREA

KAIST and Nvidia bet \$300 million on Korean-language AI research

KAIST announced a five-year, \$300 million joint AI research lab with Nvidia at its Kim Jaechul Graduate School of AI, funding at least ten researchers a year with built-in Nvidia internship and hiring pathways. KAIST separately opened a Human Physical AI research centre, and Seoul National University is now negotiating its own Nvidia lab.

The Korea Herald · 2026-07-26

Hyundai's union strikes over robots, not just wages

Hyundai Motor's 40,000-member union announced a third round of partial strikes for 29-31 July after fifteen rounds of wage talks stalled, with job-security guarantees against AI and humanoid-robot deployment on the assembly line now a sticking point alongside base pay. Industry estimates put cumulative production losses near 1 trillion won (\$675 million) if the strikes proceed.

The Korea Times (Yonhap) · 2026-07-24

JAPAN

Tokyo plans new funding channel for vocational schools

Japan's education ministry is considering a fiscal 2027 project that would channel financial support, via prefectural governments, to vocational schools training students for essential services facing acute shortages — medical care, elderly care and construction. Prefectures would assess regional labour needs together with local industry before directing funds, and the ministry is also weighing rules to expand remote classes so working adults can reskill more easily.

The Japan Times · 2026-07-21

USA

Amazon deepens its bet on an outside upskilling platform

Amazon named workforce-education platform Guild as a new partner in its Career Choice programme, giving hourly employees structured access to Guild Navigator for credentialed pathways into maintenance and reliability-engineering technician roles. Career Choice has now enrolled more than 300,000 employees globally, including 100,000 in 2025 alone.

Chain Store Age · 2026-07-24

Oregon college anchors a \$160 million semiconductor training consortium

Chemeketa Community College was named a core academic partner in the newly designated Oregon NSF FAST Engine, a statewide semiconductor consortium that has received an initial \$15 million from the National Science Foundation and could draw up to \$160 million over the next decade. The initiative aims to graduate 4,000 semiconductor-industry-ready workers a year and help create 25,000 regional jobs.

Salem Reporter · 2026-07-22

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